the Danes and the English. Like so many Indian words that crept into the English language from late-Elizabethan times onwards, it is a corruption. That quintessential portmanteau of Anglo-Indian words and their derivations *Hobson-Jobson* has this to say about it:

> **COROMANDEL**, n.p. A name which has been long applied by Europeans to the Northern Tamil Country, or (more comprehensively) to the eastern coast of the Peninsula of India from Point Calimere to the mouth of the Kistna, sometimes to Orissa … The name is in fact *Choramandala*, the Realm of Chora; this being the Tamil form of the very ancient title of the Tamil Kings who reigned at Tanjore … The name occurs in the forms *Cholamandalam* or *Solamandalam* on the great temple inscription of Tanjore.

So Coromandel takes its name from the ancient dynasty of Tamil rulers known as the Cholas. That word ‘Chola’ first appears on rock inscriptions that can be accurately dated to within a year or two either side of 260 BCE, carved by order of Emperor Ashoka, and it continues to reappear century after century on the walls and monuments of the great temple cities of Tamil country, right up to a final appearance in the year 1279 CE.

As to who first coined the word Coromandel, a young Italian adventurer from Bologna named Ludovico di Varthema has a good claim. If Ludovico is remembered at all today it is because he was the first non-Muslim European to visit Mecca, and to live to tell the tale. However, what makes Ludovico and his *Itinerario* – first published in Rome in 1510 and subsequently in English in 1577 – special and so unusual for the time is that the author’s main concern was not to enrich himself through trading in spices or slaves, or to boast about slaying idolators or saving their souls for Christ. He travelled for travel’s sake, filled, in his own words,